

Design 6: Step 5 Podcast

Transcript:

Hi there, folks. Here's a number that I want you to sit with for a second: 90,000 people. That's roughly how many people in just the United States are on the kidney transplant waiting list. Just kidney transplants - that's not liver, that's not pancreas, that's not heart. Just people out there needing kidneys.

And here's something that most folks don't know: somebody does not need to die for that number to go down. Healthy folks out there can choose to donate one kidney, and let me tell you, they are very much alive. So today we're going to talk about just that - living kidney donation, what's actually going on there, and why there are so many people out there who would be great candidates but have never even looked into it.

I spoke with a young woman named Milena. She donated a kidney about two years ago to somebody she had never met before. It was an exceptional conversation, and I was very lucky to have a moment to sit down and talk with her. Of course, the first thing I asked her was, prior to the experience, had she ever really thought about it? And let me tell you, she told me that she had not. It's something - you know - of course she had heard about being an organ donor. We've all seen that little box we can check at the DMV (a little awkward conversation between us and the staff there). She just thought it was something that was sort of relegated to that - nothing she could do while she was alive and healthy.

So I asked her what changed, and she mentioned that a friend - somebody close to her - had donated to their brother-in-law. And the thing that shocked her was that she seemed completely fine. Milena, like me, had assumed a donated kidney meant months of recovery, something really intense, something long-term that would be debilitating. But she looked it up, and it was shockingly safe. So safe we're talking about complications occurring in under one percent of cases. Really safe stuff, folks. And most donors are back to their normal routine within, at most, a few weeks. That surprised her - and me - more than anything.

And I have to say, the fear that this has the potential to upend your life kind of seems like the biggest thing standing between folks and becoming donors. For her, she was telling me she kept thinking, "What if I need that kidney later?" But she found the data - tracked for decades - showing that people who do this go on to live full, healthy lives with one kidney. When she went to the transplant clinic she ended up working with, the doctors walked her through the numbers, which gave her more peace of mind than anything she had read online.

And you might be thinking, just like I did, did anyone she loves push back on this? I mean, this is a pretty big deal. And she said, yeah, her husband was pretty nervous at first, but once they both talked to the physicians and the living donor coordinator, they felt like they understood the process much better - and he felt much more at peace. One of the things that really surprised them was that there wasn't going to be a cent out of pocket that they had to spend. Things like travel, missed work, stuff like that - all included. Having some bona fide medical professionals walk them through it apparently makes a pretty big difference.

So let's stop and double-click on that, because that really is something that surprised me: absolutely no cost, folks. Not from the recipient's insurance - the donor program and nonprofits help cover these surgeries, the testing, travel, even lost wages. These are things that can get covered. I think a lot of people just quietly assume it's going to cost them something, and that stops them from ever really finding out.

So then you may be asking: if there's no cost and the health risk is low, what's keeping people from doing it? And if I'm being honest with you, folks, I think it's simply that nobody thinks about it or questions the assumptions about how these things work. It's easy to assume that somebody else is going to step up. It's not in front of our eyes, so it's easy to let it play in the background - or, if we do think about it, to assume the waiting list will just sort itself out.

So one of my last questions for her was: what would you say to folks listening right now who maybe are curious about it but haven't looked into it? And she showed me a website - one of the places she's been pointing people to when they're curious. It's just a free screener. We're talking about five minutes of your time, folks. Five minutes. There's no commitment, nothing - it'll just help determine, at a high level, if you're a match.